and error, they learned that outrage creates engagement, and without any explicit order from above they decided to promote outrage. This is the hallmark of AI – the ability of a machine to learn and act by itself. Even if we assign just 1 per cent of the blame to the algorithms, this is still the first ethnic-cleansing campaign in history that was partly the fault of decisions made by non-human intelligence. It is unlikely to be the last, especially because algorithms are no longer just pushing fake news and conspiracy theories created by flesh-and-blood extremists like Wirathu. By the early 2020s algorithms had already graduated to creating by themselves fake news and conspiracy theories.[22]

There is more to say about the power of algorithms to shape politics. In particular, many readers may disagree that the algorithms made independent decisions, and may insist that everything the algorithms did was the result of code written by human engineers and of business models adopted by human executives. This book begs to differ. Human soldiers are shaped by their genetic code and follow orders issued by executives, yet they can still make independent decisions. The same is true of AI algorithms. They can learn by themselves things that no human engineer programmed, and they can decide things that no human executive foresaw. This is the essence of the AI revolution: the world is being flooded by countless new powerful agents.

In chapter 8 we'll revisit many of these issues, examining the anti-Rohingya campaign and other similar tragedies in greater detail. Here it suffices to say that we can think of the Rohingya massacre as our canary in the coal mine. Events in Myanmar in the late 2010s demonstrated how decisions made by non-human intelligence are already capable of shaping major historical events. We are in danger of losing control of our future. A completely new kind of information network is emerging, controlled by the decisions and goals of an alien intelligence. At present, we still play a central role in this network. But we may gradually be pushed to the sidelines, and ultimately it might even be possible for the network to operate without us.

Some people may object that my above analogy between machine-learning algorithms and human soldiers exposes the weakest link in my argument. Allegedly, I and others like me anthropomorphise computers and imagine that they are conscious beings that have thoughts and feelings. In truth, however, computers are dumb machines that don't think or feel